

## Chapter 42-1

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The system taking the initiative to remind her meant it was on Liang Shi's side.

It might have also realized that what it had given Liang Shi was a complete mess, so it was trying to help Liang Shi within the bounds of not violating the rules.

Having reached this conclusion, Liang Shi briefly abandoned her thoughts of giving up and entering complete resignation mode.

Instead, taking advantage of the system's willingness to answer, she asked several more questions.

"If the timeline of the Liang family recognizing their real daughter is moved up, what impact would that have on me?"

System: [Don't know.]

Liang Shi: "?"

"Then let me change the question. Regarding the original body's sacrifice, does the entire Liang family know about it, or is it something Qiu Zimin planned alone?" Liang Shi continued asking.

System: [Ah this... Sorry host, this question involves core story content and cannot be disclosed.]

Liang Shi: "..."

"What about the original body's background? Whose daughter is she? Does Qiu Zimin have a grudge against her parents? Or is this simply a case of babies being switched at birth?"

System: [...%¥#¥]

"Crackling" electrical sounds interfered with the system's answer, and Liang Shi's ears experienced a "baptism."

Already mentally exhausted, she became irritated by this electrical interference.

After the electrical sounds stopped, the system sighed in a human-like manner: [Host, it's not that I don't want to tell you, but all the questions you're asking touch on core story content, which we cannot reveal.]

Liang Shi: "..."

After a moment of speechlessness, Liang Shi smiled: "Then what can you tell me?"

The system fell briefly silent, then laughed with that eerie mechanical voice, "Host, you will have a bloody disaster within two days. Remember to be sincere when you go to Yunfeng Mountain tomorrow."

Liang Shi: "...?"

If this system had a physical form, it would probably be pinned to the ground and beaten up by her.

She suppressed the irritation in her heart and asked in a relatively calm tone: "Why did you send me into this book?"

System: [Ah? Sorry host, this question involves...]

"I didn't want you to answer." Liang Shi said through gritted teeth: "I wanted to say, if you want me to solve puzzles, wouldn't it be better to send me to an infinite flow<sup>1</sup> escape room game?"

System: [...]

Liang Shi: "That way I could die faster."

No need for this slow torture.

"Look at this story's plot - suspense, mystery solving, supernatural elements. If I keep investigating, is the next step going to be sending me as a sacrifice to a river god or sky god? It's already the technologically advanced 21st century, why would there still be such plotlines?!" Liang Shi took a deep breath, but still couldn't calm her anger, "Since you arranged for me to be cannon fodder, just let me exit directly! Just pretend I don't exist! Why do I still have to do tasks?!"

System: [...Sorry.]

Liang Shi: "What use is your apology?! You should give me some clues! Even police need clues to solve cases!"

System: [This world was interfered with by gods many years ago. During the repair process, there was only one sentence: everything is possible.]

Liang Shi: "..."

"Then why did you say before that the story line wouldn't collapse?" Liang Shi frowned: "When I transmigrated here, I'm like a butterfly, and one that keeps flapping its wings. Then the other side of the ocean will definitely cause a storm, and all story lines related to me will change. Haven't you been to school? Don't you know about the butterfly effect?"

By the end, Liang Shi was getting quite agitated.

The aftereffects of seeing Qi Taitai during the day were too severe. Even sleeping all afternoon hadn't completely calmed her emotions.

The system was rendered speechless.

After a while, the system said: [What I meant by the story line not collapsing is that all characters will definitely appear, and major events won't be changed. For example, your bloody disaster in the next few days. As for the chain reactions you've brought to this world, those are not within the scope of story line collapse.]

Liang Shi: "..."

Your standards for "story line not collapsing" are really low.

Liang Shi didn't want to argue with it anymore; she just wanted to give up.

Whatever happens, happens.

The system probably also sensed her bad mood and quietly disappeared.

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**Footnotes:** <sup>1</sup> Infinite flow: A popular Chinese web novel genre involving characters trapped in supernatural game-like scenarios where they must complete tasks or challenges to survive and progress.

## Chapter 42-2

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The matter of the real daughter actually didn't have much impact on Liang Shi.

On the contrary, when the real daughter returned, she could directly sever ties with the Liang family. At worst, she would just have to move out of this villa and leave the company.

Her life would continue as normal.

What made her mentally exhausted was the matter with Qi Taitai. She could ignore everything else, but this one thing alone—

Was too real.

Real to the point of suffocation.

It was just that there were no information leads whatsoever.

The rain outside was getting heavier, pattering incessantly. It looked like it wouldn't stop anytime soon, and might even continue through the night.

According to the housekeeper, every year after Haizhou City<sup>1</sup> entered autumn, it would rain for a very long time.

Coastal cities, once they started having continuous rain, would become damp, with moisture even in the air. In more severe cases, one could smell the thick fishy scent of the sea.

It was also dinnertime.

Liang Shi didn't feel like eating anything, but Xu Qingzhu still needed to eat.

She was thinking about the evening's menu in her room when there came a knock on the door—three very light taps. The sound of knuckles against wood carried a muffled quality that wouldn't make anyone feel annoyed.

"Liang Shi, time to eat." Xu Qingzhu said.

Her voice was clear and cold, but today when she spoke, she slowed down a bit, making her seem less aloof.

Liang Shi turned on the room light.

The sudden brightness was dazzling. She raised her hand to block the light, then got up to open the door.

Xu Qingzhu wore a light purple silk nightgown, her long hair covering her collarbone and the alluring curves of her chest.

This outfit made her skin appear even more fair. Combined with the dim lighting in the hallway, the only ventilated window was at the end of the corridor, where strong wind was battering the window frame, making rustling sounds.

Just standing there, Xu Qingzhu was like a light source in the dark night.

Ethereally independent, as if glowing in solitude.

Liang Shi stepped back half a step, not wanting her to discover her low spirits.

She was someone who didn't like exposing or burdening others with her bad emotions.

Shared happiness becomes double happiness, but shared sadness becomes double sadness.

So share more happiness and less sadness.

Liang Shi had always been this way.

She forced a smile, acting as if nothing was wrong, "Is dinner ready?"

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu said: "I ordered takeout."

"I slept all afternoon." When Liang Shi closed the room door, she also turned off the room light, saying gently: "This kind of weather is perfect for sleeping. I just woke up and was thinking about asking what you wanted to eat."

Xu Qingzhu hadn't asked what she did in the afternoon, yet she was volunteering information about her whereabouts.

It rather felt like trying to cover up.

Xu Qingzhu's footsteps suddenly paused, and she turned back to glance at her.

Liang Shi almost bumped into her back, forcibly stopping her steps. When she met her searching gaze, she looked away, "What's wrong?"

"Nothing." Xu Qingzhu said calmly: "Rainy days are indeed suitable for sleeping. I also slept for a while after coming back."

"Mm." Liang Shi asked: "What takeout did you order?"

She really couldn't muster any energy, despite trying very hard to pretend.

The pretense wasn't convincing.

The ending tone of every sentence was falling.

Lifeless and spiritless.

Xu Qingzhu said: "Hot pot."

Liang Shi: "?"

"Rainy days and hot pot are the perfect match." Xu Qingzhu said: "And it's spicy too. Oh right, you can eat spicy food, can't you?"

Liang Shi: "...I can."

The level of spiciness Liang Shi could accept was medium spicy, but it looked like what Xu Qingzhu had ordered was extra spicy.

A layer of Sichuan peppercorns and chili peppers floated on top, appearing blindingly red under the living room lights.

Xu Qingzhu sat down expressionlessly. All the side dishes were complete on the table; they just needed to turn on the heat and wait for the oil in the pot to boil.

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**Footnotes:** <sup>1</sup> Haizhou City: The fictional coastal city where the story takes place

## Chapter 42-3

Liang Shi felt somewhat restless and uneasy after sitting down.

The quiet environment left her not knowing what to do, and all the dishes on the table made her feel guilty.

Everything had been prepared by Xu Qingzhu herself.

She hadn't contributed anything.

Moreover, after Xu Qingzhu returned from the mall, she hadn't mentioned a single word about what happened in the morning.

Last time she had asked about Jiaojiao, but this time she said nothing at all.

Liang Shi, who was used to being questioned whenever something unusual happened, couldn't adapt to this sudden change.

Although this was the best choice for her and the most comfortable approach.

But it made her feel guilty.

Clearly, this matter was also related to Xu Qingzhu.

Qi Taitai had said in front of Xu Qingzhu that she and Qi Jiao were somewhat similar.

The information revealed was that for Liang Shi, she was just a substitute for Qi Jiao.

Yet Xu Qingzhu still gave her sufficient patience.

As long as she didn't speak, Xu Qingzhu wouldn't ask.

Liang Shi couldn't stand this somewhat oppressive atmosphere and finally couldn't help but laugh and speak up, "Where did you order the takeout from?"

"From an app." Xu Qingzhu sat there very calmly, also answering her question normally, though she frowned slightly before answering. This subtle movement was instantly caught by Liang Shi, who interpreted it as possible disdain for her ignorance.

Xu Qingzhu continued: "From a food delivery app. After ordering, they deliver it."

Liang Shi replied with little confidence: "Mm."

Then the atmosphere sank again.

Liang Shi became a bit more animated, asking: "What time did you wake up today? How long did you sleep?"

These were very boring questions.

After asking, she herself realized that these questions were actually quite elementary.

Normally, she would never ask such things.

She had always been someone with a good sense of boundaries, especially with Xu Qingzhu.

At most, she would ask "Did you sleep well?"

But now she didn't want the conversation to go cold, or rather, she didn't dare let it go cold.

She felt unsettled inside.

Xu Qingzhu looked up upon hearing this, those clear eyes carelessly scanning over, as if wanting to take in all of Liang Shi's unease and panic.

"Can't remember clearly." Xu Qingzhu still answered her question, "When I woke up, it was already dark, and the rain had been falling for a long time."

"Right." Liang Shi shrugged with forced casualness, "We were quite lucky with our timing. It started raining not long after we got back. I slept from when I got back until now, so I probably won't be able to sleep tonight."

"Then we'll watch a movie." Xu Qingzhu said: "Watch until you get sleepy, then sleep."

With this conversation, Liang Shi finally relaxed a bit.

But once Xu Qingzhu finished answering, the conversation went cold again.

That sense of urgency and unease surged up again, forcing her to find topics.

"So do you have plans tomorrow..." Liang Shi started asking again, but before she could finish, Xu Qingzhu interrupted, "Liang Shi."

She called Liang Shi's name very casually, with a touch of nonchalance, and even the gaze that swept over carried a gentle quality.

"You don't need to find topics." Xu Qingzhu said: "Just wait for the food."

Liang Shi: "..."

"I don't have anything I want to answer." Xu Qingzhu continued: "And you don't have anything good to ask. As for things like weather, they're normally not within our scope of concern, so just be yourself, okay? It's just eating a meal together. After eating, do whatever you want to do. There's no need to exhaust yourself like this."

Liang Shi instinctively wanted to explain: "I didn't..."

"I know you're waiting for me to ask about what happened this morning." Xu Qingzhu said: "But I don't plan to ask. Things you haven't figured out yourself—there's no point in me asking."

Liang Shi: "..."



She began to be amazed by Xu Qingzhu's perceptiveness and intelligence.

In such a short time, she had actually seen through all of this.

"I asked Zhao Xuning about it. Qi Taitai doesn't usually appear much in social circles, and her husband, CEO Qi of Qida Company, has built up a persona of being a doting husband and loving father. Qi Jiao is even more mysterious. She was normally a transparent person at school, but suddenly wanted to jump off a building in her third year of junior high. She didn't succeed that day and was hospitalized for a while. After changing schools, she became virtually untraceable in social circles." Xu Qingzhu laid out all the information she had learned in front of her, "If you want to investigate, you can start from Qi Jiao's side."

Liang Shi was surprised, "You... why are you helping me?"

The water began to boil.

Xu Qingzhu put a plate of meat into the pot, "Consider it helping myself."

Liang Shi: "Hm?"

Xu Qingzhu: "I don't want to eat while looking at an extremely dejected face."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Especially a dejected face that's trying to put on a happy front to make others happy." Xu Qingzhu's face was obscured by the rising steam, making her look ethereal. She had no expression as usual, her voice still clear and cold, but the words she spoke were like sunshine, warm enough to melt one's heart.

"If you're unhappy, you're unhappy. What's there to hide?" Xu Qingzhu said: "No one needs you to coax them to be happy. Everyone has the freedom to be happy or unhappy."

Xu Qingzhu placed the plate on the table, "Liang Shi, you are free."

## Chapter 42-4

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The rain indeed fell all night.

Pitter-patter, continuous and lingering.

Several thunderclaps sounded during the night, but Liang Shi slept well.

The next morning, the weather cleared up.

Liang Shi hadn't drawn the curtains at night, so she was awakened by sunlight in the morning.

Her hair only blocked half the sun, while the other half was warmed by the sunshine. When the piercing light moved to her eyes, she instinctively raised her hand to block it.

Her slender fingers spread across her face, and she curved her lips upward.

She had had a beautiful dream last night.

Liang Shi glanced at her watch—7:20.

Yesterday's rain had left quite a bit of standing water on the roads, and the news was still reporting on this.

Liang Shi was worried that Li Ran and the others might not go to Yunfeng Mountain, so she asked early: [Sister Ran, are we still going to Yunfeng Mountain?]

Li Ran: [Of course! It's not raining anymore. Still meeting at nine o'clock.]

Liang Shi: [Okay.]

Liang Shi got up to wash up, then walked to the living room. Sunlight poured everywhere, and her mood brightened considerably.

After doing some simple exercises, she went to cook.

To thank Xu Qingzhu for last night's hot pot, she deliberately made nourishing congee.

Even before going downstairs, she could smell the fragrance of the congee.

Although last night's hot pot was so spicy that Liang Shi nearly cried, it was still a very delicious meal.

Xu Qingzhu came downstairs at about the same time as usual, close to 8 o'clock.

Liang Shi's breakfast was almost perfectly timed—she had just brought it to the table when Xu Qingzhu came over.

She smiled teasingly, "Did you come down because you smelled the fragrance?"

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu even sniffed, "Even the neighbor's dog got hungry."

Liang Shi: "..."

Her smile grew even brighter.

After Xu Qingzhu got her bowls and chopsticks, she sat at the table waiting to eat, with the daily news playing on her phone.

She pinched her neck to relax herself. When Liang Shi brought over the sweet bean paste buns, she asked: "Are you going out today?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Mm, I made plans with colleagues to go mountain climbing. What about you?"

Xu Qingzhu said: "I'm meeting Sally and Cherry to go shopping."

"That sounds nice." Liang Shi said: "Have a good time shopping, buy lots of things."

Xu Qingzhu smiled, "Okay."

Her smile was the very gentle kind.

But she didn't smile often normally, so she gave people the impression of being aloof and untouchable.

Liang Shi suddenly said: "Xu Qingzhu, you look really beautiful when you smile like that."

Without any personal emotions, it was completely objective praise.

But upon hearing this, Xu Qingzhu restrained her smile, "Let's eat."

After a quiet breakfast, Xu Qingzhu was responsible for cleaning up the kitchen, while Liang Shi sat at the dining table thinking for a while, then transferred 100,000 yuan to Xu Qingzhu.

Her own account balance wasn't much left either. Now that the real daughter was about to return, she had to be ready to run at any time, needing to keep enough for rent and short-term living expenses.

So what she could give was limited; this was already the maximum amount.

Afterward, the two did their own things without disturbing each other.

Their interaction returned to normal tracks.

Liang Shi arrived punctually at the meeting point with Li Ran and the others.

Since Yunfeng Mountain was in the suburbs, Li Ran had separately hired a van.

Six people came in total: besides her and Li Ran, there was one from the editorial group, two from the gg group, and one male Alpha from the production team.

The male Alpha was jokingly said to be there to protect them.

Big Brother had an honest nature—he was the one who went with Liang Shi and the others on the follow-up shoot last time.

After returning, Liang Shi found an opportunity to give him an autograph from Zhao Ying, which made him so happy he was overjoyed. Usually, when bringing drinks, he would always bring an extra cup for Liang Shi.

The group of six got in the car. After driving for less than half an hour after leaving the city, everyone in the car had fallen asleep.

Except for Liang Shi.

## Chapter 42-5

Liang Shi had slept very well last night and wasn't sleepy at all now.

She played mobile games on her phone.

Halfway through the drive, the car started getting bumpy, waking up everyone in the vehicle. Then everyone started chatting randomly.

All about things happening at the magazine department.

Someone started a topic about the recent Minghui Jewelry.

Especially the launch event on Friday.

"Did you all watch it? Those design sketches were absolutely stunning." A female colleague from the gg group pulled up the concept art from that day, "If I weren't broke, I would have splurged."

"How much does it cost?" Li Ran asked.

"The ring is over 70,000 yuan." The female colleague said.

Li Ran: "That's not too bad, at least it's not as expensive as BARE."

"But BARE has good materials. Minghui's material quality has been declining since three years ago. Some netizens showed that it turned black in less than a month—just a pair of scrap metal." The female colleague said: "But previous years' designs weren't this good-looking. If it were 7,000 yuan, I could splurge based on looks alone."

"Speaking of Minghui, it's quite regrettable. Such a big brand, and it declined just like that." Li Ran sighed.

Another female colleague said: "It's fine, the Sheng family<sup>1</sup> people are back in charge, so they should be able to save it. Their current CEO is just a waste, with no management talent whatsoever. Back when Minghui was so glorious under Old Master Sheng, now his granddaughter has joined the company—I think she can make it work."

Li Ran: "Old Master Sheng's granddaughter? My god, Sheng family people are all geniuses."

"What about Old Master Sheng's daughter then? If she were a genius, how could she let her husband ruin Minghui like that?" The female colleague said.

Li Ran was silent for two seconds, then said very sincerely: "Facial genius also counts as genius... right?"

The female colleagues: "..."

"But speaking of it, Sheng family people really are beautiful." The female colleague passed over her phone, "Universal divine beauty, facial genius. Just holding one launch event and she already has fans online, some fans are even buying Minghui products specifically for her."

Li Ran glanced at it, then glanced again, then looked toward Liang Shi.

Liang Shi cleared her throat softly.

Li Ran returned the phone, then pretended to act as if nothing happened and commented, "No one in the Sheng family has ever grown up ugly. Have you all seen the photos of Sheng Qinglin<sup>2</sup> circulating online? Incredibly handsome! Even in today's entertainment industry, he'd still crush all those pretty boys."

"..."

So everyone started discussing the entertainment industry.

After the Sheng family topic cooled down, Li Ran secretly sent Liang Shi a message: [Good heavens!]

Liang Shi: [...?]

Li Ran: [Your wife is actually from Minghui Jewelry!]

Liang Shi: "..."

She thought everyone already knew.

Minghui Jewelry might have declined in reputation in the outside world, but among these people who worked in luxury brand circles, it still held significant status.

They might have heard of Minghui Jewelry's great name even when they were still in school.

It might even appear in university coursework.

This little episode quickly passed.

Yuyin Daoist Temple<sup>3</sup> was located high up on Yunfeng Mountain—not at the peak, but not far from it either.

They climbed stone steps from the foot of the mountain.

Since it was the weekend, quite a few people had come.

Liang Shi exercised regularly, so her stamina was much better than these people who often sat in offices. Before long, she had walked to the front, walking alongside Big Brother from the production team. Big Brother even secretly asked her about the audition.

She said she hadn't received any news yet.

Big Brother then asked her: "If you pass, won't you be able to act alongside my goddess?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Should be."

Big Brother showed a yearning expression, "So envious."

Liang Shi was infected by his emotion and couldn't help saying: "If there's a chance in the future, I'll call you to be an extra on set."

Big Brother: "...Forget it, I'm too ugly, not suitable."

"Not all actors need to be good-looking." Liang Shi said: "Just extras anyway."

Big Brother was tempted, "Really? Then I'll thank you in advance."

After a while, Big Brother said again: "Xiao Liang<sup>4</sup>, you're really too kind—beautiful and kind-hearted. You'll definitely become hugely popular in the future."

Liang Shi smiled, "Then I'll take your auspicious words."

The mountain climbing process wasn't too troublesome, except Li Ran gave up halfway up the mountain, complaining about why she had the crazy idea to come to a Daoist temple while setting a flag<sup>5</sup> that she would definitely exercise properly after going back, striving not to be the most embarrassing one next time.

With such a "loudspeaker" along the way, everyone's attention was diverted quite a bit.

They successfully arrived at Yuyin Daoist Temple.

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**Footnotes:** <sup>1</sup> Sheng family: Xu Qingzhu's maternal family, the original founders of Minghui Jewelry

<sup>2</sup> Sheng Qinglin: Xu Qingzhu's uncle who died young in a car accident <sup>3</sup> Yuyin Daoist Temple: A

Daoist temple on Yunfeng Mountain where mysterious rituals may have taken place <sup>4</sup> Xiao Liang:

"Little Liang" - an affectionate way to address someone younger or junior <sup>5</sup> Setting a flag: Internet slang for making a bold declaration that often gets proven wrong

## Chapter 42-6

The Daoist temple had flourishing incense offerings. The cauldron in front of the main hall was filled with incense sticks, wisps of smoke drifting toward the sky, and devout worshippers knelt on prayer mats.

As soon as she arrived at the temple, Liang Shi excused herself to use the restroom and separated from the others.

Many people treated this place as a tourist attraction, and it was indeed quite modernized.

One courtyard even had a large tree with lush branches and leaves, hung with wooden plaques, red cloth strips, and tied lovers' knots—many people's wishes hanging there.

After many years, this place had long since become different from what Liang Shi had seen in her dreams, but standing at the temple's best vantage point for viewing the scenery, it was about eighty percent similar to what Liang Shi had previously seen in her dreams.

With limited time, she went directly to find the temple's management personnel, "Excuse me, is Daoist Master Yunyin<sup>1</sup> here?"

The other person wore gray robes and, after looking Liang Shi up and down, replied: "Our Daoist Master travels the four directions, with no fixed return date. This benefactor should come another day."

"Is there any way to contact him?" Liang Shi asked: "I have urgent business with him."

"Everyone who comes here has urgent business." The other replied: "But the Daoist Master has been traveling for many years, rarely returning home. We don't know his whereabouts."

His voice was unhurried, speaking slowly, giving Liang Shi a headache.

She couldn't tell if he was playing taiji<sup>2</sup> with her or if the Daoist Master really wasn't there.

Liang Shi asked: "What about your Daoist Master's phone number?"

The other: "..."

Liang Shi was surprised: "He can't possibly not have a phone, right? You don't all communicate by brain waves, do you? Carrier pigeons?"

The other: "..."

"Well, there is one." The other said: "However, our Daoist Master's whereabouts are always uncertain, and he rarely turns on his phone. Moreover, many people seek him out, so we never reveal the Daoist Master's contact information. You should wait until he returns from his travels before asking."

Liang Shi: "..."



Anyway, it was just one sentence: not giving it.

Liang Shi held onto one last hope, "Can you perform sacrificial rituals?"

The other looked completely baffled: "What do you mean?"

"Using people as sacrifices to exchange for certain things." Liang Shi said.

The other was horrified, "Benefactor, this is a proper place. We never engage in illegal business. What you're saying sounds so sinister!"

Liang Shi: "..."

It seemed he truly didn't know. Liang Shi gave up and left her phone number with him.

When the other asked for her name, she hesitated for a moment, then said: "My name is Xu Qingzhu."

She was afraid that if the Daoist Master Yunyin knew her name, he would contact Qiu Zimin first.

So she gave Xu Qingzhu's name instead.

The other noted it down, "Alright, when the Daoist Master returns, I will definitely contact you."

Afterward, the other also said: "Our temple also provides fortune-telling, matchmaking, and other services. You can check out the Tianji Pavilion<sup>3</sup> for specifics."

Liang Shi agreed.

Then she contacted Li Ran and the others, and together they went to the main hall to pray for peace talismans.

While praying, she asked for several more, getting them for Xu Qingzhu, Liang Xinhe, Sun Meirou, and Ling Dang.

Originally, she hadn't planned to get them for others, but remembering that Xu Qingzhu said Big Brother had also stood up for her that night, she got one for Liang Xinzhou as well.

Then she thought of Zhao Xuning in the hospital, where medical disputes could easily occur, so she got one for Zhao Xuning too.

After that, she thought of Zhao Ying, who had always supported her, so she got one for Zhao Ying as well.

In the end, she got so many that everyone exclaimed, "Are you here for wholesale?"

Liang Shi was helpless, "Can't help it, too many people to give them to."

Since Li Ran had gotten one for Zhou Li, she didn't get one for her.

Liang Shi had thought of every person around her who was good to her. After getting the peace talismans, they all went to Tianji Pavilion together.

Walking along the way, Li Ran said: "If they really could reveal heavenly secrets, these people would definitely have the five disadvantages and three deficiencies<sup>4</sup>, right?"

"What if it's real?" A female colleague said: "My friend said the fortune-telling here is very accurate."

Li Ran: "That's also true. Since we're already here."

Liang Shi came with a neutral attitude. Previously, she indeed didn't believe in these things much.

But now, she felt there might be something to it after all.

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**Footnotes:** <sup>1</sup> Daoist Master Yunyin: "Cloud Hidden" Daoist Master, the mysterious religious figure who may have performed the ritual involving the original Liang Shi <sup>2</sup> Taiji: The practice of being evasive or non-committal in conversation, literally referring to the philosophical concept of yin and yang <sup>3</sup> Tianji Pavilion: "Heavenly Secrets Pavilion" where fortune-telling services are provided <sup>4</sup> Five disadvantages and three deficiencies: Traditional Chinese belief that those who reveal heavenly secrets will suffer from various misfortunes in life as punishment

## Chapter 42-7

There were many people in Tianji Pavilion, with three "masters" in total, each with long queues in front of them.

So they split up to queue separately.

The reason masters were masters was because they spoke little.

Everyone who ran to them for fortune-telling would finish in three to five sentences. They never said a few extra words just because you paid more money.

So Liang Shi doubted their abilities.

Perhaps that Daoist Master Yunyin had some real ability, but these... were probably all fraudsters.

With this mindset, she sat across from the master.

The one telling her fortune was an older man, simply dressed with a kind countenance. After looking at her palm, he suddenly raised his head to carefully examine her face.

Liang Shi didn't dare miss any of his expressions. After seeing Liang Shi's face, the other showed a surprised expression.

She didn't know if he was surprised she was still alive or surprised to see her here.

The other said quietly: "We meet again."

—Again?

Liang Shi didn't let this opportunity slip and followed his words: "Yes, it's been quite a while since we last met. How about it? What can you help me divine this time?"

The other sighed, "That you're still alive shows your life force is tenacious. What do you want to divine this time? Marriage?"

Liang Shi's gaze suddenly turned fierce, "Why don't you help me divine where Daoist Master Yunyin has gone?"

The other frowned, "What for?"

"Just to have a chat with him." Liang Shi sneered: "What else could I do? You people want money without conscience or life, but I still value mine."

The other sighed softly, "The past is past, why dwell on it? Let's divine future matters instead."

Liang Shi said: "For you it's the past, but for me it isn't. Those things you set up in my room, the marks you left on my body, nearly killed me. If it were you, would you forget this debt?"

Liang Shi lowered her voice, extremely restraining her emotions.

Actually, she was also suppressing her guilt.

She didn't know how much the person in front of her understood about the matters between the original body and Daoist Master Yunyin.

She was just trying to fish for information.

If she said something wrong, she might lose the chance to get information.

"Acting on someone's commission to fulfill their trust." The other's tone was calm, "As long as you're fine now, that's good. If you're here to question and cause trouble, you may leave first. There are many people waiting behind."

Liang Shi asked viciously: "Commissioned by whom? Fulfilling whose trust?"

The other: "...No comment."

"It's my mother, isn't it?" Liang Shi smiled, "Actually, you have no real abilities. It's just that my mother wanted to use your hands to destroy me, even kill me. Your sacrificial formations are all fake, but those sinister things are enough to destroy a person's mind."

The other: "Benefactor, please leave."

"The Dao follows nature, cause and effect cycle, everything is destined." The other said: "That you could escape from the formation is already extremely fortunate, but you cannot say the formation is fake."

"I don't know what you want to divine today, but you will have a bloody disaster within two days, the location being your workplace. Be extremely careful. Also, your Hong Luan star<sup>1</sup> is moving. The destined person and you already have your red thread<sup>2</sup> entangled together, but the journey is full of hardships. If you can cut through thorns and smooth the rough paths, the rest of your life will definitely bring prosperous fortune and family happiness."

Liang Shi: "...?"

How did he start making promises?

But last night the system also said she would have a bloody disaster within two days.

What kind of bloody disaster would it have to be for both of them to give her warnings simultaneously?

And the fact that it coincided with the system's words—did that mean this person also had some real ability?

Liang Shi still had a bunch of things she wanted to ask, but the other had already gotten up and left.

By the time she came to her senses, the person was gone.

...

They stayed at the temple for lunch, eating vegetarian dishes that had no particular flavor.

Liang Shi had things on her mind and had no appetite either.

In the afternoon, they said they wanted to climb to the mountain peak, but Liang Shi said she wanted to stay at the temple—there were still some places she hadn't visited.

So they split up.

Liang Shi searched the entire temple but couldn't find the fortune-teller from the morning. Even if she had found him, she probably wouldn't have been able to get anything out of him anyway.

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**Footnotes:** <sup>1</sup> Hong Luan star: In Chinese astrology, the star associated with romance and marriage

<sup>2</sup> Red thread: In Chinese mythology, an invisible red thread connects those destined to be lovers or spouses

## Chapter 42-8

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On the other side of the city, Memory Restaurant.

After Xu Qingzhu finished eating with Sally and Cherry, they sat there chatting for a while.

Talking about everything under the sun.

Work had finally ended, so they could finally relax a bit.

Sally slammed the table and said: "I want to go clubbing!"

Cherry: "You can tell you're not a decent person."

Sally: "?"

"To be fair, you've been clubbing more times than me." Sally defended herself, "And I go to proper places."

Cherry: "What you're talking about was in the past. I haven't been to those kinds of places since graduating from university—too noisy."

Sally was left speechless by this response and indignantly sought arbitration from Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu spread her hands, "I think what Sally said is right, and Cherry isn't wrong either. Those who like clubbing can go clubbing, those who like wellness can do wellness. All's well that ends well."

Sally and Cherry looked at her in unison, "Fence-sitter!"

Xu Qingzhu smiled.

There was no helping it.

Who told these two to always argue over meaningless little things?

Cherry also discussed future work plans with Xu Qingzhu. She could help Xu Qingzhu for about another year. After Xu Qingzhu established herself at Minghui or successfully revived Minghui, she would start her own independent studio. Xu Qingzhu expressed complete understanding.

Sally, on the other hand, would always stay at Minghui.

In her words, working anywhere was still working.

After they finished chatting, they got up, and Xu Qingzhu paid the bill.

After leaving the restaurant, Xu Qingzhu told the two of them to wait in the lounge area while she went to use the restroom.

Sally suddenly patted Cherry: "Look, isn't that Junior Weiwei?"

"Still calling her junior?" Cherry rolled her eyes, "Just a little white lotus<sup>1</sup>."

Sally: "..."

She didn't dwell on that term anymore, but excitedly said: "She went to the same place as Blanche!"

Cherry was very calm, "There's only one restroom. What's strange about going to the same place? Anyway, Haizhou City is only so big—they'll run into each other sooner or later."

Sally: "..."

Instantly calmed down.

Xu Qingzhu didn't know that Bai Weiwei had also come to this mall and had dined at the same restaurant.

But when she came out, she saw Chen Liuying.

She wore a black mask, and because her face was small, some skin showed on both sides of the mask, appearing whiter than when she'd seen her before.

She had dyed her hair a new color—yellowish.

The kind of yellow that would look very ugly without sufficiently fair skin.

But Chen Liuying pulled it off well.

However, Xu Qingzhu didn't like her, and by extension disliked her looks.

No matter how beautiful she was, she was just a "phoenix vase<sup>2</sup>."

After hearing what Lin Luoxi had told her, Xu Qingzhu was even more convinced this was just a parasite sucking blood from Bai Weiwei.

She had tried sending text messages to Bai Weiwei before, but they all sank without a trace.

Now that they met, there wasn't much to say.

But while she was washing her hands, Chen Liuying suddenly came over, pressing her body against Xu Qingzhu's back, saying in a low voice: "You're Xu Qingzhu, right? You're very beautiful."

Xu Qingzhu frowned and directly elbowed her, but this didn't make her body move away. Instead, she leaned in closer, laughing softly in her ear: "You're even more beautiful in person than in videos. But why aren't you wearing that black tight top? That would make your figure more... taut."

As she spoke, her gaze also wandered toward Xu Qingzhu's chest.

This was unbearable.

Xu Qingzhu pushed her away, directly shoving her against the wall.

Even pressed against the wall, she still didn't forget to take verbal advantage, "I was complimenting you, darling. You really are beautiful."

Xu Qingzhu frowned in disgust: "Does Weiwei know how disgusting you are?"

Chen Liuying smiled, "People all like beautiful things. I'm just appreciating beauty. Why would that be disgusting?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

As she spoke, she leaned toward Xu Qingzhu, who directly pushed her away. As a result, she was shoved against the wall, her head even hitting it, making a very heavy thudding sound.

...

That didn't make sense.

She didn't have that much strength at all.

What followed was an angry shout, "Xu Qingzhu, what are you doing?"

Xu Qingzhu turned around to see Bai Weiwei storming over angrily, "Even if you have issues with me, you don't need to physically assault her, do you?"

Xu Qingzhu went from initial bewilderment and shock to helplessness in less than half a minute.

"I didn't hit her." Xu Qingzhu explained.

"I saw it all!" Bai Weiwei said: "Having Liang Shi steal Chen Liuying's role wasn't enough for you, now you have to assault people when you meet them? Are you still the Xu Qingzhu I know? Why aren't you pretending anymore? Where's your aloofness? Does this place allow you to hit people?!"

"I said I didn't hit anyone." Xu Qingzhu said: "Weiwei, don't you believe me?"

"Why should I believe you?" Bai Weiwei looked at her with disgust, "I saw the moment you struck."

"But didn't you see her sexually harassing me?" Xu Qingzhu confronted her, "Chen Liuying came over first to flirt..."

"Ha." Bai Weiwei sneered, "Xu Qingzhu, just how many more lies are you going to make up? You really will stop at nothing to achieve your goals."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She gave up arguing with Bai Weiwei and turned to leave, but Bai Weiwei grabbed her wrist, "Stop right there."

Xu Qingzhu frowned and turned back, "What?"

Bai Weiwei paused, but said firmly: "Make Liang Shi give up the role of Han Sui."



"What?" Xu Qingzhu was shocked.

"I said, you make Liang Shi give up the role of Han Sui, or I'll post the video of what you just did online." Bai Weiwei said: "Your Minghui Jewelry, which just got a new lease on life, will fall into another public opinion crisis because of your behavior. And Liang Shi's career will be stillborn before it even starts. You know the power of the internet—it's more terrifying than either of us can imagine."

Xu Qingzhu stared at her, her eyes showing shock, incomprehension, and pain.

She couldn't understand why a friend who had once been so close could become what she was now.

But after a moment, Xu Qingzhu shook her head, "No, Liang Shi would never give up this role."

"As long as you ask, she'll do it." Bai Weiwei said: "I know she listens to you very much now."

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes, then said firmly: "But I won't make her give up."

"This is something she worked hard to fight for. I won't let down her efforts."

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**Footnotes:** <sup>1</sup> White lotus: Chinese internet slang for someone who appears innocent and pure on the surface but is actually manipulative <sup>2</sup> Phoenix vase: Someone who is beautiful but useless, like an ornamental vase